TUBE AUDIOBOOKS

THE WORKBOOK

A GUIDE TO EMOTIONAL REGULATION

FROM ANCIENT TIMES

Five Ancient Practices to Train Your Emotions,
Stop Reacting, and Become Unstoppable

A Tube Audiobooks Companion Workbook

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

This workbook mirrors the five ancient practices covered in the audiobook, one section per chapter, in the same order you encountered them. Each section opens with a brief recap of the idea, a quote worth returning to, and then a worksheet built directly from the five practical steps taught in that chapter, now expanded with follow-up questions that push each step a little deeper than a single line ever could.

You do not need to complete every section in one sitting, and you do not need to work through them in order. Some people find it more useful to keep this workbook nearby and turn to a single section only when the situation it addresses actually arises, using it the way the original practitioners did: as a tool reached for in the moment, not a curriculum to finish.

Each section also includes a short Practice Tracker, a simple table for logging each time you return to that technique. Revisiting these entries after a few weeks is often where the real insight appears, not in any single session, but in the pattern across many small ones.

Before You Begin

- A pen and a journal. This is a digital workbook, so rather than writing on these pages themselves, simply follow the guided prompts and questions on each one, and answer them, honestly, in your own journal.
- A quiet ten minutes — no session here requires more.
- Permission to write an imperfect, unfinished answer. This is a working document, not a performance.

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CHAPTER ONE

The Stoic View from Above

(Greco-Roman Stoicism)

THE CORE IDEA

Marcus Aurelius trained himself to mentally rise above his own troubles, picturing his body, his tent, his city, and eventually the entire earth, shrinking beneath him until his problem was reduced to the scale of a single grain of sand. Modern research on psychological self-distancing confirms what he discovered through repetition alone: the further away a threat appears, the less urgently your nervous system needs to react to it.

A QUOTE TO SIT WITH

> *"You have power over your mind, not outside events. Realize this, and you will find strength."*
>
> **— Marcus Aurelius, Meditations**

THE PRACTICE

STEP 1 Name the Trigger

What specific event, comment, or thought triggered this reaction? Name the emotion in one word.

- *On a scale of 1 to 10, how intense did this feel in the first sixty seconds?*

- *What story did your mind immediately attach to this event — the meaning you gave it, not just what happened?*

STEP 2 Zoom Out

Picture yourself rising above the room, the building, the city, the whole curved earth. From that height, how large does this problem actually look?

- *What does this situation look like from one year in the future?*

- *Who else, right now, is carrying something far heavier than this? (Not to minimize your feelings — to right-size them.)*

STEP 3 Ask the Dichotomy of Control

Is this situation actually within your control, or only your judgment about it? What part, if any, can you influence?

- *What specifically can you do in the next twenty-four hours that falls entirely within your control?*

- *What are you currently trying to control that was never yours to control in the first place?*

STEP 4 Talk to Yourself by Name

Using your own name, write one sentence of advice you'd give yourself right now, as if coaching a friend.

- *What would you tell a close friend if they described this exact situation to you?*

STEP 5 Reflect on the Gap

Now that some distance has passed, what changed between your first reaction and how you feel now?

- *Rate the intensity now, 1 to 10. How does it compare to your rating in Step 1?*

- *What did this exercise teach you about how quickly your reactions can shift?*

REFLECT

✦ *Think of a situation that reliably triggers you. If Marcus Aurelius observed it from orbit, what might he notice that you currently can't?*

✦ *What is one belief you are currently treating as fact that might actually just be your interpretation?*

PRACTICE TRACKER

DATE	TRIGGER	VIEW FROM ABOVE — NOTES	HOW I FELT AFTER

CHAPTER TWO

Pratipaksha Bhavana

(Patanjali's Yoga Sutras)

THE CORE IDEA

Rather than fighting a destructive thought directly, Patanjali taught that the mind is far more effectively redirected by deliberately summoning its precise opposite and holding attention there until the original thought loses its grip. Modern clinical work, from Wolpe's reciprocal inhibition to Linehan's opposite action skill, has since confirmed the same underlying mechanism.

A QUOTE TO SIT WITH

> *"When disturbed by negative or unwholesome thoughts, one should cultivate opposite, positive thoughts."*
>
> **— Patanjali, Yoga Sutras 2.33**

THE PRACTICE

STEP 1 Catch It Early

What is the destructive thought or urge you noticed? How early did you catch it?

- *What physical sensation told you this thought had arrived — a tight chest, a clenched jaw, a racing pulse?*
- *How many times today has this same thought already shown up before now?*

STEP 2 Name the Precise Opposite

What is the specific, concrete opposite of this thought? (Not "positivity" in general — be exact.)

- *If the negative thought is an accusation, what is the specific counter-evidence against it?*
- *Who in your life embodies this opposite quality, and what would they do differently here?*

STEP 3 Engage the Body

As you hold the opposite thought, what physical shift did you make — breath, shoulders, jaw?

– *Rate your physical tension before and after this shift, 1 to 10.*

STEP 4 Hold It Longer Than Feels Necessary

Sit with the opposite thought for at least sixty seconds. What did you notice as you held it?

– *At what point, if any, did it start to feel more believable, even slightly?*

– *What did the original thought feel like once you finally let it go?*

STEP 5 Practice on Something Small

Describe a low-stakes moment this week where you could rehearse this before you truly need it.

– *What is the smallest possible version of this practice you could try today?*

REFLECT

✦ *What is a negative thought pattern you return to often? What would its genuine opposite look and sound like?*

✦ *Where in your life could doing the opposite of an unhelpful urge serve you better than following it?*

PRACTICE TRACKER

DATE	NEGATIVE THOUGHT	CULTIVATED OPPOSITE	RESULT

DATE	NEGATIVE THOUGHT	CULTIVATED OPPOSITE	RESULT

CHAPTER THREE

Naikan Reflection

(Traditional Japanese Psychology)

THE CORE IDEA

Naikan asks three deceptively simple questions about a specific person and a specific period of time: what have I received, what have I given, and what troubles have I caused. The practice exists to correct a well-documented bias in human memory, our tendency to overestimate our own generosity and underestimate what we've been given, replacing a distorted ledger with an honest one.

A QUOTE TO SIT WITH

> *"We are loved more than we love, helped more than we help, and forgiven more than we forgive."*
>
> **— A principle central to Naikan teaching**

A NOTE ON REPETITION

These three questions were never meant to be asked only once. Return to this worksheet again and again, with a different person and a different period of time each time — a parent, a partner, a sibling, a friend, a colleague, even yourself at an earlier age. Each new pass tends to surface something the last one didn't.

THE PRACTICE

STEP 1 Choose Your Person and Timeframe

Name one person and one specific period of time — a year, a season, a single month.

- *Why did this particular person and this particular period come to mind first?*

STEP 2 What Have I Received?

List concrete, specific moments of care you received from this person during that time.

- *Which of these did you notice and appreciate at the time, and which are you only truly seeing now?*

STEP 3 What Have I Given?

List what you gave this person in return during that same period — honestly, without padding.

– *Was any of what you gave given reluctantly, or with strings attached?*

STEP 4 What Troubles Have I Caused?

List the difficulties, large or small, that you caused this person during that period.

– *Which of these, if any, did you ever fully acknowledge to this person, out loud?*

STEP 5 Notice the Balance

Reading back over your three answers, what surprised you most?

– *Which of the three lists was hardest to write, and what do you think that difficulty says?*

– *What is one thing you might say or do differently with this person now?*

REFLECT

✦ *Is there someone you currently feel resentment toward? What might a Naikan reflection on them reveal that your usual story leaves out?*

✦ *What is one small act of care you received this week that you almost didn't notice?*

PRACTICE TRACKER

Use one row every time you sit down with a new person or a new relationship — this tracker is designed to be filled in repeatedly, not once.

DATE	PERSON / TIMEFRAME	KEY INSIGHT

CHAPTER FOUR

Chöd Visualization

(Tibetan Psychological Practice)

THE CORE IDEA

Where avoidance quietly teaches the nervous system that a feared thing was worth running from, Machig Labdrön's Chöd practice asks you to do the opposite: to turn toward what frightens you and offer it something, rather than fighting it. This is, in essence, the same principle behind modern exposure therapy — approached with generosity instead of gritted teeth.

A QUOTE TO SIT WITH

> *"Approach what frightens you. Offer it generously, rather than fighting to push it away."*
>
> **— A pith instruction long attributed to Machig Labdrön**

THE PRACTICE

STEP 1 Personify the Fear

Give your fear a shape, image, or presence. Describe it as specifically as you can.

- *How long has this fear been part of your life, in some form?*

- *What does this fear most want you to believe about yourself?*

STEP 2 Ask What It Wants

If this fear could speak, what would it say it actually wants from you?

- *Is what it wants actually about protecting you, even if clumsily?*

STEP 3 Offer It Something

What could you generously offer this fear, rather than fighting or suppressing it?

- *What would change if you treated this fear as a part of you to care for, rather than an enemy to defeat?*

STEP 4 Stay a Little Longer

Sit with the discomfort for a few extra breaths before moving on. What shifted?

- *What did you expect to happen that didn't?*

STEP 5 Start Small

What is a smaller, more manageable version of this fear you could practice approaching first?

- *What is one small, concrete action you could take this week toward that smaller version?*

- *Who could support you as you practice this?*

REFLECT

✦ *What is a fear you've been avoiding rather than facing? What has that avoidance actually cost you?*

✦ *What would it look like, practically, to feed this fear instead of running from it?*

PRACTICE TRACKER

DATE	FEAR FACED	WHAT I OFFERED IT	OUTCOME

DATE	FEAR FACED	WHAT I OFFERED IT	OUTCOME

CHAPTER FIVE

Premeditatio Malorum

(Seneca / Marcus Aurelius)

THE CORE IDEA

The Stoics deliberately rehearsed loss, in specific and vivid detail, not to invite despair but to strip future misfortune of the shock of total surprise, and to feel, by contrast, real gratitude for what remains. Handled carefully and briefly, imagining what you could lose turns out to be one of the most reliable routes to appreciating what you still have.

A QUOTE TO SIT WITH

> *"He robs present ills of their power who has foreseen them coming."*
>
> **— Seneca, Letters to Lucilius**

THE PRACTICE

STEP 1 Set a Bounded Window

Note today's date and give yourself five to ten minutes — no more. This is rehearsal, not rumination.

STEP 2 Imagine the Setback in Detail

Choose one realistic potential setback. Describe it vividly and specifically.

- *What would be the very first moment you'd realize this had happened?*
- *What is the worst-case version of this, and how likely is it, honestly?*

STEP 3 Rehearse Your Response

What resources, people, or values would carry you through it?

- *Who is one specific person you would call first?*
- *What have you already survived that proves you could survive this too?*

STEP 4 Return and Appreciate

Come back to the present. What do you have right now that you just imagined losing?

- *When did you last express real appreciation for this out loud?*

- *What is one small way you could honor this today, now that you see it clearly?*

STEP 5 Close with the Reserve Clause

Write your own version of "fate permitting" — a phrase reminding you that you're meeting the future prepared, not controlling it.

REFLECT

✦ *What is something, or someone, you love that you may be taking for granted simply because it's still here?*

✦ *How might your relationship to a current worry change if you fully rehearsed how you'd cope with it?*

PRACTICE TRACKER

DATE	SCENARIO REHEARSED	COPING PLAN	WHAT I APPRECIATED

DATE	SCENARIO REHEARSED	COPING PLAN	WHAT I APPRECIATED

INTEGRATION

Bringing the Five Practices Together

Five cultures, five centuries, five completely different methods — and yet every one of them arrives at the same quiet conclusion: your emotions are not a verdict handed down from outside, they are a conversation you are already having with yourself. Use the table below as a quick guide to which practice tends to fit which kind of moment, until reaching for the right one becomes instinct rather than effort.

WHICH PRACTICE FITS THE MOMENT?

When You're Feeling…	Reach For
Overwhelmed by a big problem	**The Stoic View from Above**
Caught in a destructive thought loop	**Pratipaksha Bhavana**
Resentment toward someone close to you	**Naikan Reflection**
Avoiding something out of fear	**Chöd Visualization**
Anxious about loss, or taking something for granted	**Premeditatio Malorum**

YOUR REFLECTION

✦ *Looking back across all five sections, which practice did you find yourself reaching for most naturally? Why might that be?*

✦ *Which practice felt hardest — and what might that difficulty be pointing you toward?*

QUICK REFERENCE CARD

A condensed glance at all five practices — keep this page nearby for the moments you need it fast.

1. The Stoic View from Above

1. Name the trigger.
2. Zoom out mentally, as far as you can.
3. Ask what's actually in your control.
4. Coach yourself by name.
5. Notice the gap once it passes.

2. Pratipaksha Bhavana

1. Catch the thought early.
2. Name its precise opposite.
3. Engage the body as you hold it.
4. Hold it longer than feels necessary.
5. Rehearse it on something small first.

3. Naikan Reflection

1. Pick a person and a timeframe.
2. What did I receive?
3. What did I give?
4. What trouble did I cause?
5. Notice the balance — then repeat with someone new.

4. Chöd Visualization

1. Personify the fear.
2. Ask what it wants.
3. Offer it something, generously.
4. Stay with it a little longer.
5. Start with a smaller version first.

5. Premeditatio Malorum

1. Set a bounded window of time.
2. Imagine the setback vividly.
3. Rehearse your response.
4. Return and appreciate what remains.
5. Close with “fate permitting.”